Lesson 08 material: The Paragraph 1: Format, Parts, Title and Topic Sentence

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

Unit 3 Parts and Characteristics of a Good Paragraph (part I-VI)

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Original page, with audio and online exercises: https://harpercollege.pressbooks.pub/academic-writing-skills/chapter/unit-3parts-of-a-paragraph/
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Unit 3 Parts and Characteristics of a Good Paragraph

Learning Objectives

1. To identify the parts of a paragraph: title, topic sentence, supporting sentences with details, concluding sentence, and transitions
2. To understand how each part relates to one another within a paragraph through multiple examples
3. To learn the key characteristics of a paragraph: format, unity, cohesion, and completion through multiple examples
4. To practice writing each part of a paragraph with key characteristics through a variety of exercises

I. Warm-Up

(Picture: a group of children laughing and running outdoors)

a group of children laughing and running outdoors

Read the paragraph “Missing My Childhood Days” below and do the activities that follow.

Missing My Childhood Days

Thanks to two people and one place, my childhood was filled with fun. The first special person was my cousin Hector. I was the only child to my mom, and he was the only child to his mom. We were not lonely because we played and enjoyed family trips together. I loved playing hide and seek with him the most. The running, anticipating[1], shouting, and laughing will always be in my memories. Secondly, I really miss my best friend Lisandra from my elementary school. Our moms were best friends, so it was easier for us to do many things together. For example, we used to explore the resorts and hotels near our homes. We imagined how we could decorate our own houses as elegantly as the hotels. Additionally, Lisandra had a little sister called Lolanda, and we loved to play with her and care for her as if she were our own baby. We fed her and sang songs to her. Even though I lost contact with Lisandra after she switched to a different school, our time together was very precious to me. Lastly, I really miss my childhood home. It was a big house with a patio decorated with pots of beautiful flowers. The house was large enough for me to ride my bike inside. There was also a pool. We had many family parties there. Playing riddles[2] by the poolside was one of the most popular games among us. Nowadays I do not have Hector and Lisandra in my life, and my childhood house has long

been sold. However, I am grateful for having them all in my past because they have left me with priceless[3] memories.

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Discuss in groups:

1. What are your most unforgettable childhood memories? Why are they unforgettable?
2. What three areas of childhood does the author miss the most?
3. What is the main idea of the above paragraph? Where do you find it in the paragraph?
4. Where is the title?
5. How does the author begin the paragraph?
6. What is the spacing between one line to the next?
7. Does each new sentence start a new line?
8. What do you think a paragraph is?
9. What do you like about this paragraph?
10. How would you improve the paragraph?
11. If you could ask the writer a question, what would you ask?

II. Definition of a Paragraph

A paragraph is a group of sentences about one main idea. The goal of a paragraph is to communicate to the readers what you think of a topic (your main idea) and why you believe this way (your supporting ideas). A paragraph also follows a certain format. Paragraph writing is the foundation[4] for all types of academic writing assignments such as essays and research papers.

III. Paragraph Format

You can see the format of a paragraph from "Missing My Childhood Days":

1. Center the title in the middle of the top line.
2. Start the paragraph with indentation (a few open spaces in the beginning).
3. Type or write double spaced.
4. Each sentence follows the one before it without starting a new line.
5. Use font size 12 if you type. (The font size may be hard for you to determine in this web-book.)

IV. Parts of a Paragraph

Understanding each part of a paragraph is an important step to good writing. One way to do this is to identify and color code each part.

Title – ***pink*** Topic sentence – ***red*** Supporting sentences – ***green***

Supporting details – ***blue*** Concluding sentence – ***red*** Transitions – ***yellow***

When you color code the parts, you know that

1. you understand the paragraph organization.
2. you are not missing any important compone**n**ts.
3. all the parts are in the right order.

4. the supporting details (**blue**) should be the longest and the most detailed.

Missing My Childhood Days

Thanks to two people and one place, my childhood was filled with fun. The first special person was my cousin Hector. I was the only child to my mom, and he was the only child to his mom. We were not lonely because we played and enjoyed family trips together. I loved playing hide and seek with him the most. The running, anticipating, shouting, and laughing will always be in my memories. Secondly, I really miss my best friend Lisandra from the elementary school. Our moms were best friends, so it was easier for us to do many things together. For example, we used to explore the resorts and hotels near our homes. We imagined how we could decorate our own houses as elegantly as the hotels. Additionally, Lisandra had a little sister called Lolanda, and we loved to play with her and care for her as if she were our own baby. We fed her and sang songs to her. Even though I lost contact with Lisandra after she switched to a different school, our time together was very precious to me. Lastly, I really miss my childhood home. It was a big house with a patio decorated with pots of beautiful flowers. The house was large enough for me to ride my bike inside. There was also a pool. We had many family parties there. Playing riddles by the poolside was one of the most popular games among us. Nowadays I do not have Hector and Lisandra in my life, and my childhood house has long been sold. However, I am grateful for having them all in my past because they have left me with priceless memories.

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Exercise 1. Use Paragraph "Missing My Childhood Days" as an example. Read Paragraph "Difficulties in English Writing" and identify the parts with the following colors:

Title – **pink** Topic sentence – **red** Supporting sentences – **green**

Supporting details – **blue** Concluding sentence – **red** Transitions – **yellow**

Difficulties in English Writing

For me, writing is one of the most difficult skills to learn in English. First, with writing comes spelling. Many words are pronounced the same but spelt completely differently, like flower and flour, blue and blew. I need extra efforts to learn and remember how to spell and write them correctly. Another challenge I face in English is sentence structure. There are many types of sentences in English such as simple, compound, and complex. Each type has its own punctuation rules. It takes a lot of hard work to understand how to build sentences effectively. Finally, grammar is challenging. My professors emphasize the importance of grammar because it plays a significant role in writing. Unfortunately, it is also one of the difficulties for me because it has many, many rules and exceptions. For example, in count and noncount nouns unit, there are many confusing words like police and family. At first, I thought the word "police" was singular, but in fact it is plural. In contrast, I thought the word "family" was plural, but it is singular in many situations! Mistakes in singular and plural nouns lead to errors in verbs. Despite all these difficulties in spelling, sentence structure, and grammar, writing remains to be one of my favorite aspects of learning.

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Read the above two paragraphs again, and you can see that a good paragraph consists of:

1. **A title** – to show the topic and catch the readers' interest ***pink***
2. **A beginning called the topic sentence** – to show the main idea ***red***
3. **A middle called the supporting sentences and details** – supporting sentences to explain the main idea ***green*** ; details to explain the supporting sentences ***blue***
4. **Transitions or connecting words** – to connect the ideas and guide the readers ***yellow***
5. **An ending called the concluding sentence(s)** – to finish the paragraph ***red***

(Picture: a hamburger)

a hamburger

Paragraph Organization – the Hamburger Way

To make a tasty hamburger, you need to take time to get the ingredients ready and stack[5] them up carefully. Planning and organizing your ideas for a good paragraph can be very similar to making a hamburger.

(Picture: parts of a hamburger between two hands)

parts of a hamburger between two hands

1. The sesame seeds on the top piece of bread is what you see as you unwrap a hamburger. It is like the **title** of a paragraph.
2. The top piece of the bread is the first part of the hamburger. It is like **the topic sentence**.
3. The middle part is what makes the hamburger delicious. The more ingredients you add, the tastier the hamburger is. This part is like **the supporting sentences with details**. More details for the paragraph will make it more interesting to read.
4. You also add condiments like mustard, ketchup, and mayonnaise to not only make the hamburger juicier but also help the other ingredients like tomato slices and beef patties stick together. Those condiments are like **transitions**.
5. The last piece of the bread makes the hamburger complete. The bread is made with the same ingredients as the top piece but with a different shape. This is like **the concluding sentence.** It restates the topic sentence but in a different way.

Below, you are going to learn how to write each part.

V. Title of a Paragraph

A title gives the readers information about what you write in the paragraph. It usually states or implies[6] the topic of your writing.

1. A good title is often very short. Sometimes it is only one word or one phrase. It is usually not a complete sentence.

The Best Invention

The Reasons for My Mediterranean Diet

The Characteristics of a Good Boss

2. A good title catches the readers' interest. It tells the readers about the main topic, but it does not tell everything.

Why Not Studying Hard?

A Long-Kept Secret

To Mask or Not to Mask

3. A good title follows capitalization and punctuation rules.

- The first letter of the first word is always capitalized.
- Do not capitalize a short preposition, an article, or a coordinating conjunction unless it is the first word.
- Never capitalize the entire title.
- Do not put a period at the end.
- Do not put quotation marks around the title.
- Do not underline the title.

Discuss each pair of the titles below and notice how the errors are corrected.

the day I arrived in Chicago **X**

(Picture: lots of books showing titles on shelves)

lots of books showing titles on shelves

The Day I Arrived in Chicago √

THE MAKING OF A DOCTOR **X**

The Making of a Doctor √

A Very Frustrating Experience. **X**

A Very Frustrating Experience √

“Advice from My Mother” **X**

Advice from My Mother √

The Mysterious Noise **X**

The Mysterious Noise √

For more explanations and examples in capitalization, please refer to Appendix B Capitalization. (Open Appendix B here.)

Exercise 2. Here are the titles of some paragraphs. Do they follow the rules? Write the correct title in the box. After you finish all the titles, you can check your answers by clicking the “Check” button. You may retry the exercise or see all the answers.

***Example**:*

From my home to school

Correction: From My Home to School

EXERCISE

1. the best ESL program _____

2. A SURPRISE VACATION _____

3. The Most Important Person In my life. _____

4. our writing classroom _____

5. My Most Important Day _____

6. “The Best High School Math Teacher” _____

VI. Topic Sentence

A topic sentence is a sentence that contains the main idea of a paragraph. It is usually put in the beginning of a paragraph. A good topic sentence has two essential parts and one optional part:

1. the topic of your paragraph
2. the controlling idea – your attitude/opinion about the topic
3. (optional but preferred) predictors – the points you are going to explain in the body of the paragraph

In each pair of topic sentences below, one contains the topic and controlling idea. The other has the topic, controlling idea, and predictors. Identify each part and discuss which topic sentence you like better. Explain your reasons.

- My writing class is important in helping me prepare for college study.
- My writing class is important in helping me prepare for college study because I learn how to plan, write, and edit my own writing.
- I enjoy three aspects of my writing class.
- I enjoy three aspects of my writing class: my professor, my classmates, and the course materials.
- Many students feel stressed out in the writing class for three reasons.
- Because of long class periods, daily homework assignments, and lots of tests, many students feel stressed out in the writing class.,
- Writing in English is very different from writing in my native language.
- Writing in English differs from writing in my nature language in style, sentence structure, and punctuation.

Rules for a good topic sentence:

1. It must be a complete sentence that contains a subject and a verb.

(Picture: a light bulb surrounded by six circles)

a light bulb surrounded by six circles

- My interesting writing class (not a complete sentence) **X**
- How to improve writing skills (not a complete sentence) **X**
- My writing class is interesting for three reasons. (a complete sentence) √

- In my writing class, I am learning how to improve writing skills in three ways. (a complete sentence) √

2. It can be a positive or negative statement, not a question. If you ask a question in the beginning of the paragraph, you should answer it in the next sentence. That second sentence is the topic sentence.

- Why is learning English important? (a question) **X**
- What is the best way to improve writing skills? (a question) **X**
- Why is learning English important? It is so because good English skills benefit people in their study, work, and daily life. (The second part is the topic sentence.) √
- What is the best way to improve writing skills? I have three suggestions for ESL students to improve writing skills. (The second part is the topic sentence.) √

3. Narrow down your topic. General topics are difficult to focus on and write.

- Year 2020 was a difficult year for me. (too broad) **X**
- The COVID pandemic in Year 2020 made it difficult for me to study. (more specific) √
- The COVID pandemic in Year 2020 made it difficult for me to study for three reasons: my classes went totally online in March, I could no longer use the college library and the Language Lab, and the poor Internet connection at home often interrupted my study on the course Blackboard site. (more specific) √

4. Do not make an announcement.

- In this paragraph, I am going to talk about the disadvantages to online learning. (an announcement) **X**
- Let me explain the disadvantages to online learning. (an announcement) **X**
- This paragraph is about the disadvantages to online learning. (an announcement) **X**
- There are three disadvantages to online learning. (not an announcement) √
- There are three disadvantages to online learning: no immediate feedback from the professors, no interactions with the classmates, and unstable Internet connection at home. (not an announcement) √

5. Do not write a fact because your opinion (the controlling idea) is missing.

- Harper College is a community college. (a fact) **X**
- My classmates come from twelve different countries. (a fact) **X**
- Harper College offers the best ESL programs in Illinois in three aspects: experienced professors, free tutoring, and the Language Lab. (Controlling idea “best” is added.) √
- Representing twelve countries, my classmates are great resources for learning different cultures. (Controlling idea “great resources for learning different cultures” is added.) √

Exercise 3. Read the following topic sentences. Identify the topic, controlling idea, and predictors. Type your answers in the boxes. When you complete the entire exercise, you can click “Check” for feedback. You may retry or see all the answers.

Example:

I miss my high school life for three reasons: friends, sports, and time for myself.

topic: my high school life

controlling idea: miss for three reasons

predictors: friends, sports, time for myself

EXERCISE

1. Writing is the most difficult skill to learn in English because I am not familiar with the writing style, it is hard to have new ideas, and the sentence structure is challenging to me. Topic _____ Controlling idea _____ Predictors _____ _____ _____

2. Writing good paragraphs is easy if you follow these steps. Topic _____ Controlling idea _____

3. International students at Harper College prepare for life in the U.S. in several ways: academic study, social life, and community service. Topic _____ Controlling idea _____ Predictors _____ _____ _____

4. My college cafeteria is very different from what I imagined. Topic _____ Controlling idea _____

5. Nuclear power is our greatest hope for solving the energy crisis. Topic _____ Controlling idea _____

6. Nuclear power is the greatest threat to life on the planet. Topic _____ Controlling idea _____

7. I do not like television commercials for three reasons. Topic _____ Controlling idea _____

8. Televison commercials are insulting to women through the products, the images, and the language. Topic _____ Controlling idea _____ Predictors _____ _____ _____

Exercise 4. Are the following good topic sentences? If not, why not? How do you improve them? Click "True" for good topic sentences and "False" for the wrong ones. You will receive instant feedback after each sentence. If a topic sentence is wrong, you will see the correction and explanation in **blue**.

Example:

Electric cars

This is not a good topic sentence because it is not a complete sentence and the controlling idea is missing.

Correction: I like electric cars more than gas-powered cars.

EXERCISE

1. 1. Electric cars are becoming more popular among young people. (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 2. A Tesla is an electric car. (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 3. I am going to write about my first exciting trip to Florida in my Tesla. (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 4. Are seat belts necessary? (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 5. Seat belts do not always save lives. (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 6. The benefits of owning a car: it is convenient, it saves time, and it provides freedom. (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 9. A college degree is good. (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 7. Full-time college students should not have a full-time job because it is not good for their physical, mental, and social life. (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 8. Is too hard to focus on study in an online class. (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 9. In this paragraph I will compare working on campus and working off campus. (True / False)

Links on the original page

- Web page (chicago.suntimes.com): https://chicago.suntimes.com/crime/2021/7/3/22561910/chicago-weekend-shootings-july-2-5-homicide-gun-violence
- All Rights Reserved: https://choosealicense.com/no-license/

Appendix B Capitalization

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Original page, with audio and online exercises: https://harpercollege.pressbooks.pub/academic-writing-skills/chapter/appendix-bcapitalization/
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Appendix B Capitalization

(Picture: some capital letter cutouts in a box)

some capital letter cutouts in a box

Capitalization in English may be different from that in other languages in many ways. Before you start, remember that it is wrong to write a whole piece of writing in all capital letters. Instead, you should capitalize letters only when appropriate.

I. Capitalization Rules

1. Capitalize the first letter of the first word in a sentence.

- **Books** are expensive here.
- **Two** textbooks cost me over a hundred dollars.

2. The pronoun "I' is always capitalized when referring to oneself.

- **I** am a student.
- You and **I** are both students.

3. The first letters of all the words related to specific names of continents, countries, nationalities, ethnicities, and languages are always capitalized.

- My classmates come from **Asia**, **Europe**, **Africa**, **North America**, **Central America,** and **South America**.
- They are from **Korea**, **India**, **Ukraine**, **Egypt**, **Mexico**, **Guatemala**, and **Peru**.
- They are **Korean**, **Indian**, **Ukrainian**, **Egyptian**, **Mexican**, **Guatemalan**, and **Peruvian**.
- They speak **Korean**, **Gujarati**, **Ukrainian**, **Arabic**, and **Spanish**.

4. The specific names of the months and days of the week are always capitalized.

- The fall semester usually runs from late **August** to mid-**December**, spring from mid- **January** to mid-**May**, and summer from early **June** to end of **July**.
- Most classes run on **Mondays** and **Wednesdays**, or **Tuesdays** and **Thursdays**.

5. Capitalize the first letter of each word in the proper nouns (except prepositions, articles, coordinating conjunctions, and "to" in an infinitive).

Proper nouns are specific or exact names of people, places, companies, colleges, cities, countries, nationalities, religions, holidays, product brands, school courses, etc. Do not capitalize the common names unless they are the first word in a sentence.

Please refer to Unit 16 Nouns for more explanations and examples about common nouns and proper nouns. (Open Unit 16 here.)

Common Nouns (General Names)	**Proper Nouns (Specific or Exact Names)**
There are many international students in **American** colleges.	In **Spring 2016**, there were 107 international students at **Harper College.**
Those international students came from 26 different countries.	They came from **Brazil**, **Congo**, **China**, **Qatar**, **Moldova**, etc.
Of course, many languages were represented by those students.	Those languages included **Portuguese**, **French, Chinese**, **Arabic, Romanian**, etc.
They also believed in different religions.	Some of the religions were **Christianity**, **Islam**, **Buddhism**, and **Hinduism**.
At **Harper**, some international students take ESL reading and writing courses for one or two semesters.	The advanced ESL courses are **Reading V** and **Writing V**.
All the courses are taught by experienced professors.	They are usually taught by **Professor Nelson** and **Professor Garcia**.
Of course, textbooks are required.	In Reading V, the textbook is "**Reader's Choice**".
Other international students take classes in computer, business, and science.	Some of the popular courses are **CSC 121**, **ACC 101**, and **Bio 160**.
The fall and spring semesters are 16 weeks long, while the summer semester is only 8 or 10.	In **Summer 2021**, ESL students took their writing class in 10 weeks and reading class in 8 weeks.
Most international students plan to transfer to other universities after they finish their study at **Harper**.	Many **Harper** students transfer to **University of Illinois at Chicago** and **University of Illinois at Champion-Urbana**.
The student clubs at **Harper** help them meet friends.	**The International Students Club** provides games, prizes, and snacks besides the opportunities to meet friends.
Most student clubs meet once a week.	**The International Students Club** meets every **Thursday** afternoon.
The clubs hold their regular meetings in one of the buildings on campus.	A few clubs meet in **Building D**.
Sometimes, the college president comes to greet the students.	**Dr. Proctor, Harper**'s current president, has been very impressed with what the clubs are doing.
Many international students love the museums, parks, and lakes in **Chicago**.	Their favorite places are **Museum of Science and Industry**, **Millennium Park**, and **Lake Michigan**.
During the holidays, **Chicago** hosts many celebrations and events.	On 4th of **July**, **American's Independent Day**, there are usually fireworks. **Taste of Chicago** also attracts many people.

The number of international students and their countries of origin are taken from http://dept.harpercollege.edu/international/documents/GoingGlobalFebruary2016.pdf

II. Capitalization in Titles

1. **Capitalize the first letter of all major words (nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs, and pronouns)**
2. **Do not capitalize articles (a, an, the), prepositions (in, on, from, etc.), and coordinating conjunctions (and, but, or, etc.). However, capitalize them if they are the first words in the titles.**
3. **Do not capitalize "to" in an infinitive unless it is the first word in the title.**

- **The Best ESL Program**
- **The Story** of **Our Mother** and the **Little Cat**
- **My Reasons** for **Taking** a **Writing Course**
- **Five Interesting Way**s to **Make** a **Living**

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